

LIMITATIONS

Grad Cafe entries are voluntary, self-reported application results, so this dataset is not a random sample of all graduate applicants. People with unusually positive or negative outcomes may be more likely to post, some programs may have more active users than others, and one person can report several applications under different result URLs. Deduplicating URLs prevents repeated imports but does not turn entries into unique people or verified decisions. The snapshot is also uneven across terms: 29,597 entries are for Fall 2026, while only 192 are for Fall 2025. Consequently, the Fall 2025 acceptance result of 47.92% (92 of 192 entries) describes this small set of reports; it is not an official university acceptance rate or an estimate of an individual applicant's admission chances.

Missing or delayed decisions can further change that percentage, because its denominator includes all Fall 2025 entries. Missing fields and inconsistent scores also limit the comparisons. GPA is available for 18,118 of 30,020 entries, whereas GRE, GRE Verbal, and GRE AW are available for only 2,392, 2,006, and 1,887 entries respectively; each average therefore describes a different subset. Among Fall 2026 reports, accepted entries average 3.78 GPA and rejected entries average 3.79, using 7,271 and 8,152 reported GPAs. This small difference cannot establish a causal effect of GPA because program mix, other qualifications, and selective reporting are uncontrolled. Score validity is a further concern: 1,438 stored GRE values fall outside the current Quantitative range of 130-170, and 80 GRE AW values fall outside 0-6. The resulting means of 259.90 and 8.34 should not be interpreted as valid current-scale test-score averages; mixed scales, inaccurate reports, or earlier extraction issues may contribute. This assignment preserves the supplied numeric data rather than guessing corrections. Finally, original and LLM-based name matching both return 28 for the selected CS PhD acceptance query, but equal totals do not validate every standardized name or eliminate classification errors